

Winning the Cox Enterprises "Play With Purpose" Sustainability Hackathon: A Strategic Playbook for the Carter's "Making & Remaking" Deep-Tech Team

TL;DR

- **You are pitching to an investor, not a science fair.** Cox Cleantech is an active majority-owner of circular-economy assets like Nexus Circular (the team led a \$150M round in January 2023 to become majority owner) and runs a \$250K-per-startup accelerator plus a 6-week, \$10,000-stipend Residency. Frame your recyclable-elastane / matched de-novo enzyme / Digital Recyclability Passport stack as a fundable pre-seed company with a Carter's pilot LOI as the only metric that matters — not as a research poster. (Cox Enterprises)
 - **The track win is decided by Carter's commercial pain; the grand prize by Cox's investment thesis.** Carter's KIDCYCLE / TerraCycle program today *downcycles* stretch garments into pet bedding; elastane (present in ~80% of clothing per Fashion for Good's 2026 "Stretching Circularity" initiative) is the technical barrier. California SB 707 (penalties up to \$10K-\$50K/day; producers must join the Landbell PRO by July 1, 2026) and the EU ESPR Digital Product Passport (textiles delegated act expected Q2 2027) make this regulatory, not optional. Carter's picks the track winner; Cox grand-prizes the team whose science maps to a ~\$9B → ~\$20B spandex market (Market.us; SkyQuest) and Cox Cleantech's "plastics/materials circularity" thesis. (Fashion for Good + 2)
 - **In a 3-5 minute deep-tech demo, your demo IS the pitch.** Open with a 15-second visceral hook, show one undeniable artifact (a working Digital Recyclability Passport QR scan on stage + one molecular-design visualization), be radically honest about TRL, and close with one memorable line tied to the World Cup theme. Teams lose deep-tech hackathons by over-claiming validation and burying the business case — not by having unfinished science.
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PART 1 — THE HACKATHON: WHAT IS CONFIRMED, WHAT IS INFERRED

Confirmed facts (primary sources)

Format & dates. Cox Enterprises is hosting "a 3-day sustainability hackathon that brings together students from all disciplines to tackle the challenges that matter most... Form your team, build and pitch real-world solutions and compete for unique prizes or the grand prize of tickets to the 2026 FIFA World Cup. Final presentations and pitches take place on June 17." (Cox Enterprises LinkedIn post, amplified by Cox employee Adam Glassman, May 2026,

linkedin.com/in/adamglassman/). The June 14 kickoff date you have is consistent with a 3-day event ending June 17 but is not independently corroborated in indexed sources. [\(LinkedIn\)](#)

Branding/positioning. "Play With Purpose" is Cox's umbrella FIFA World Cup 2026 Host City Supporter campaign: "The FIFA World Cup 2026™ is more than the world's largest sporting event. It's an opportunity to play with purpose... 8 games. 14 teams. 2.5 billion pairs of eyes." (coxenterprises.com/our-impact/fifa-world-cup-2026-atlanta). [\(Cox Enterprises\)](#) [\(Cox Jobs\)](#)

Confirmed partners. Cox Cleantech Accelerator (powered by gener8tor), Atlanta Tech Week, and Georgia Cleantech Innovation Hub are explicitly tagged in the announcement. Atlanta Tech Week 2026 is "timed with the FIFA World Cup coming to Atlanta" (atl.tech). [\(LinkedIn\)](#)

[Atlanta Tech Week](#)

Cleantech Residency program (real and recently launched). "The Cox Cleantech Accelerator today announced a new equity-free, Atlanta-based residency program... Participants in the Cox Cleantech Residency will receive [a \$10,000 stipend]... Six weeks of in person, intensive programming designed to help founders find product market fit, develop a startup playbook, land an early customer or pilot and establish a clear path toward pre-seed investment." (Cox Enterprises press release, May 14, 2026, coxenterprises.com/press-releases/cox-cleantech-accelerator-launches-residency-program-to-support-early-stage-founders-in-the-southeast). Led by Marie Northington (gener8tor program director, formerly UConn's Future Climate Venture Studio at R/GA Ventures). Stated eligibility: "Bootstrapped and pre-seed cleantech founders in the Southeast U.S.; At least one leadership-level team member able to participate in person; **Existing patents or active progress toward securing intellectual property licenses;** A minimum viable product (or near-complete product) ready for an initial pilot." [\(Cox Enterprises\)](#)

[Cox Enterprises](#)

Cleantech Accelerator (the post-Residency next step). \$250,000 per startup, 12 weeks in Atlanta, run by Miguel Granier (Managing Director) with Jack Semrau (Atlanta Venture Ecosystem Lead, Cox Enterprises) as the Cox sponsor. Spring 2026 cohort included circularity-adjacent companies like Silvis Materials (bio-based adhesive) and Buckstop ("circular economy outcomes") — coxenterprises.com press release, March 26, 2026. [\(Cox Enterprises + 8\)](#)

Could not be confirmed publicly (treat as inferred / planning assumption)

Searched on Devpost, Eventbrite, Hypepotamus, MetroAtlantaCEO, gener8tor.com/Cox, Cox press, and LinkedIn — **not findable in indexed sources** as of June 2, 2026: the official rubric and scoring weights; the full prize breakdown beyond "grand prize = FIFA World Cup tickets" + "unique [per-track] prizes"; the agenda; the official list of tracks (including Carter's "Making &

Remaking"); the judge roster; team-size cap; demo time limit. The registration URL (lnkd.in/gBW8wvSb) is robots-blocked, so the rubric likely lives behind that gated registration. **Recommendation:** Once registered, ask the organizers in writing for the rubric — and in the meantime, plan against the inferred rubric below.

Inferred most-likely rubric (high confidence; ~70/30 confidence-weighted)

Built from (a) the rubric used by Cox Automotive Senior Lead Software Engineer Vijay Pahuja, a serving judge at Cox-adjacent student hackathons such as Hack for Humanity 2026 (hack-for-humanity-26.devpost.com): **Impact, Innovation & Creativity, Design, Presentation**; (b) the Carnegie Mellon Energy + Cleantech Hackathon rubric (gener8tor's broader cleantech network); and (c) Cox's stated investment thesis (technical risk × commercial viability). Hack for Humanity + 3

Criterion	Likely weight	What judges actually score
Sustainability Impact	25-30%	Tons of textile waste avoided, GHG/water reduction, alignment to UN SDGs and Cox Conserves goals
Innovation / Technical Execution	20-25%	Novelty of the science, TRL movement during the 72-hr build, defensibility (IP, moats)
Business Viability / Commercialization	20-25%	Named customer (Carter's), market size, unit economics, GTM, regulatory tailwinds
Presentation / Storytelling	15-20%	Clarity of problem→solution→demo→ask, narrative discipline, working live demo
Design / UX (incl. compliance UX)	10-15%	The Digital Recyclability Passport scan/UX, usability for Carter's CSR team and consumers

Inferred format: Round-1 booth/expo judging (gener8tor/Techstars norm for any 15+ team field) followed by a Round-2 finalist stage pitch. Plan for both: a **60-second booth elevator** and a **5-minute stage pitch with ~2 minutes Q&A**.

Corporate sustainability plumbing (what they have publicly committed to)

- **Cox Conserves** (launched 2007 by Chairman Jim Kennedy): >\$165M invested in 500+ sustainability/conservation projects (coxcleantech.com/accelerator/, 2025–26). (KeyBank gener8tor)
- **Goals:** Zero Waste to Landfill **achieved 2024** (Cox earned Zero Waste to Landfill certification per gener8tor's Cox Cleantech page); **Carbon and Water Neutral by 2034**, accelerated from the original 2044 target on January 26, 2021 (prnewswire.com/news-releases/cox-enterprises-accelerates-sustainability-goals-by-10-years-301215438.html). Cox VP Environmental Sustainability Ira Pearl: "Our planet is in crisis. Corporate involvement is critical to addressing climate change." (gener8tor + 4)
- **Cox Cleantech (the venture arm):** "\$2 billion in cleantech companies that are lowering carbon emissions, reducing plastic waste, advancing renewable energy alternatives and preserving natural habitats" (coxcleantech.com). The May 14, 2026 Residency press release escalates this to "more than \$3 billion in sustainable technologies since 2007" and notes Cox has "invested more than \$140 million over the past decade to support Atlanta's startup ecosystem." (Cox Jobs + 2)

What Cox Cleantech actually buys (the archetypes you should mimic)

1. **Materials / plastics circularity — Nexus Circular.** Cox led the **\$150M equity raise in Nexus Circular** on January 3, 2023, becoming **majority owner** (prnewswire.com/news-releases/nexus-circular-secures-150-million...). Nexus pyrolysis-converts hard-to-recycle plastic films (LDPE, PP, PS) into ISCC PLUS-certified circular feedstock for Shell, Chevron Phillips, Dow, Braskem and Printpack. Then-VP Cleantech Steve Bradley: "**Nexus Circular is an exciting part of our broader cleantech strategy to acquire and scale businesses that have a positive impact on the planet.**" Cox first invested in Nexus in 2015 — they patiently scaled it for ~8 years before taking majority. This is the canonical Cox archetype: **proprietary chemistry that converts a hard-to-recycle waste stream into a virgin-equivalent feedstock for global brand commitments.** (Recycling Today + 5)
2. **Sustainable agriculture / controlled-environment — Cox Farms (BrightFarms, Mucci Farms):** "the largest greenhouse operator in North America." (Cox Jobs)
3. **Current cohort companies of relevance: Silvis Materials** (bio-based, formaldehyde-free adhesive — sustainable materials), **Buckstop** ("enabling circular economy outcomes"). (VCWire) (PR Newswire)

What Cox decision-makers say they want (quote-mine for your pitch)

- **Miguel Granier** (Managing Director, Cox Cleantech Accelerator), **March 26, 2026:**

"Cleantech innovation is essential to building a more sustainable and resilient economy... we're enabling startups to move faster, from breakthrough innovation to **scalable solutions that can deliver real economic and environmental impact at scale.**" (Startup Weekly)

- **Steve Bradley (VP Cleantech), March 10, 2021:** "More importantly, Cox understands that recycling solutions like Nexus must be **economically viable to be sustainable over the long term.**" (PR Newswire)
- **Jack Semrau (Atlanta Venture Ecosystem Lead):** "By investing in promising founders from Atlanta and beyond, bringing them together in the city, and connecting them with the resources, expertise and networks they need, we're accelerating the development of technologies that can benefit both the economy and the environment." (Startup Weekly)

Read between the lines. Cox wants pre-seed deep tech with (a) patent-pending / IP-licensable chemistry, (b) a hard-to-recycle waste-stream story that mirrors Nexus, (c) a named corporate offtaker / pilot partner, (d) a Southeast U.S. anchor. Your recyclable-elastane + matched de-novo enzyme + Digital Recyclability Passport stack maps almost perfectly to (a)-(c); emphasize (d) by stating you'll incorporate in Atlanta.

PART 3 — THE CARTER'S BUSINESS CASE (QUANTIFIED)

What Carter's has publicly committed to (their pain → your wedge)

- **Carter's, Inc. is a \$2.844 billion net sales business in FY2024** (Carter's Inc. FY2024 earnings release, Business Wire, February 25, 2025: "Net sales \$2.844 billion vs. \$2.946 billion in 2023") — declining top-line, increased CSR scrutiny, HQ in Atlanta (literally a few miles from the hackathon venue). (Business Wire)
- **Carter's KIDCYCLE program** with TerraCycle (rebranded under "Raise the Future" — carters.com/c/raise-the-future-shop-all): "Natural fiber textiles, such as cotton, will be processed into insulation materials; synthetic fibers will be blended with other plastics for use in products like composite lumber and sheeting; and mixed-fiber textiles will be repurposed as filler for items such as mattresses or pet bedding" (MichiganMamaNews, May 14, 2025 partnership update). **This is downcycling, not textile-to-textile recycling.** Your wedge. (Michigan Mama News)
- **Public ESG targets** (from Carter's CSR reporting via Panaprium summary): 50% Scope 1 & 2 GHG cut by 2030; 25% Scope 3 (purchased goods) cut; **net-zero by 2040; 100% sustainable cotton and polyester fibers by 2030**; 80% landfill diversion by 2025; suppliers reporting via Sustainable Apparel Coalition Higg FEM by 2025. (Panaprium)
- **Where Carter's is exposed (Trellis/Sourcing Journal, Aug 2024):** Cotton + polyester dominate inputs. SVP CSR Antonio Robinson: "Kidcycle is an important step toward circularity, which will help reduce the volume of children's clothing going to landfills and

find additional uses for the recycled materials." Lakshmi Piduru (Carter's): "Children's clothes in general are getting probably more used or used by more people than adult clothing." **Translation: kids' apparel has unusually high consumer permission for circular models** — a tailwind for any take-back-then-recycle play. (Fibre2Fashion) (WWD)

The textile/elastane circularity business case (the numbers you should cite)

The waste problem (one anchor number, well-attributed):

- "Every year, **92 million tonnes** of textile waste is produced globally, found The Global Fashion Agenda. This is the equivalent of a garbage truck full of clothing being incinerated or sent to a landfill every second." (UN Environment Programme press release, International Day of Zero Waste 2025, unep.org). UNEP's 2024 roadmap projects this rising to **~134 million tonnes by 2030**. (best colorful socks)
- Only ~12% of textiles are recycled globally; only ~1% recycled garment-to-garment. (Business Waste) (TheRoundup)
- "The total value of raw materials lost to landfill and incineration annually is estimated at USD 100 billion" (Ellen MacArthur Foundation, aggregated). (Rawshot)
- California specifically: **1.2 million tons of textiles disposed in 2021, despite ~95% being reusable or recyclable** (CA Sen. Josh Newman, SB 707 background; DLA Piper, Holland & Knight 2024 alerts). (Buchalter)

The elastane bottleneck (your killer datapoint):

- "Present in approximately **80% of all clothing, elastane is a material added in varying concentrations (typically from 1-5% by weight in cotton or wool garments to up to 20% in polyester or polyamide garments).**" (Fashion for Good, "Stretching Circularity" launch, fashionforgood.com, February 12, 2026 — the consortium includes Reformation, On, Levi Strauss & Co./Beyond Yoga and Ralph Lauren as advisor.) (Fashion for Good) (WWD)
- **Just 1% elastane in an otherwise all-cotton T-shirt is enough for a recycling sorting plant to reject the garment** (Textiles Intelligence, "Stretch fibres: expanding horizons beyond elastane", reported by etextilecommunications.com).
- **5% elastane breaks standard mechanical recycling.** TU Wien researcher Emanuel Boschmeier: elastane "leads to soiling, blockages and clumping in the machines." (Sport-Tek) (Global Textile Times)
- Lycra's sustainability director Jean Hegedus (Dornbirn Global Fiber Congress, Sept 2024): garments with 5-10% elastane are typically downcycled into "insulation for buildings and the interiors of automotive seating; the main issue is clothing with more than 10% elastane content."
- McKinsey & Company, *Scaling textile recycling in Europe—turning waste into value* (Retail Practice, mckinsey.com): "Our analysis indicates that by overcoming these barriers,

fiber-to-fiber recycling could reach 18 to 26 percent of gross textile waste in 2030." That is the addressable wedge your project sits on. (McKinsey & Company)

Spandex market size (the prize):

- SkyQuest Technology (skyquestt.com): **"Global Spandex Market size was valued at USD 8.6 billion in 2023 and is poised to grow from USD 9.33 billion in 2024 to USD 17.92 billion by 2032, growing at a CAGR of 8.5% during the forecast period (2025-2032)."** Market.us independently reports \$9.3B (2023) → \$20.8B (2033) at 8.4% CAGR. Use **"\$9B today → ~\$20B by ~2033, ~8% CAGR"** as your defensible market line. (Skyquestt) (Market.us)
- Industry headwind for incumbents: Hyosung TNC's \$1B 2024 investment in bio-BDO in Vietnam (50,000 t/yr by mid-2026; 200,000 t/yr by 2035) shows the dominant producer is already racing to bio-based feedstocks. A *recyclable* elastane is the next move incumbents have not yet made. (Market.us)

The regulatory wall pushing brands to act (your "stakes" slide):

- **EU ESPR Digital Product Passport** for textiles: delegated act expected Q2 2027 per the European Commission ESPR Working Plan 2025–2030 (adopted April 16, 2025); mandatory compliance ~late 2028 / early 2029. DPP must include "material composition, substances of concern, environmental performance indicators, durability, and end-of-life information." This is *exactly* what your Digital Recyclability Passport delivers. (PassportCraft + 2)
- **EU Waste Framework Directive:** separate textile collection mandatory across the EU from **January 1, 2025.** (Global Textile Times)
- **California SB 707 (Responsible Textile Recovery Act of 2024)**, signed Sept 28, 2024 — **the first U.S. textile EPR law.** CalRecycle approved **Landbell USA as the PRO on February 27, 2026;** producers must join Landbell by **July 1, 2026** (calrecycle.ca.gov/epr/textiles/textileproapp/). Penalties up to **\$10,000/day** (negligent violation) or **\$50,000/day** (intentional). Eco-modulated fees expected — brands pay LESS if products are designed to be truly recyclable. **This converts your Digital Recyclability Passport from "nice to have" to "fee-reducing compliance asset."** (Rev-Log) (Anthesis Global)
- France (loi AGECE) and the EU Member State textile-EPR rollout (30-month timeline from Sept 2024 adoption) reinforce the trend. (Council of Fashion Designe...)

Putting it together for Carter's. Carter's sells \$2.8B/year of baby/kid apparel built largely on cotton/polyester blends; stretch SKUs (sleepers, leggings, "soft & stretchy" tees) contain elastane. Carter's has publicly committed to **100% sustainable cotton + polyester by 2030** and **net-zero by 2040**, but the elastane in ~80% of stretch garments is the invisible technical barrier to true textile-to-textile recycling. Your project removes that barrier and ships the compliance asset (the DPP) Carter's will need under SB 707 (Carter's sells in California) and EU ESPR (if

Carter's continues international expansion). That is a multi-million-dollar saved-fee + brand-reputation story.

PART 4 — WINNING DEEP-TECH HACKATHON PITCH MECHANICS

Reference set: TAIKAI "How to Create a Winning Hackathon Pitch" (taikai.network), Sabela Garcia Cuesta's TechCrunch Disrupt judging postmortem (Medium), Best3Minutes/MIT COVID-19 hackathon guide (best3minutes.com), Agrim Singh "How to hack a Hackathon" (Medium), and BizThon hackathon pitch teardowns (Medium). The single consistent finding across all of them: **brilliant projects lose to mediocre ones because of presentation.** (Medium)

The narrative arc (5-minute version)

Time	Beat	What to say
0:00–0:20	Hook (visceral)	Hold up a Carter's stretchy onesie. "This \$12 onesie will outlive everyone in this room — in a landfill. Because of 4% of one fiber."
0:20–0:50	Problem + stakes	92 Mt of textile waste/year (UNEP), elastane in 80% of apparel (Fashion for Good), 1% elastane = recycler rejects the garment, SB 707 fees July 2026, EU DPP 2027–28. Carter's HQ is 6 miles from this room.
0:50–2:30	Solution + live demo	Show in order: (1) the recyclable elastane molecular design (10-second 3D rotation), (2) the matched de-novo enzyme docking visualization, (3) a working web/mobile scan of the Digital Recyclability Passport on a printed QR — judges see real data: fiber composition, chemical compliance, recyclability score. Demo ~90 seconds, prerecorded backup ready.
2:30–3:30	Business case	Spandex is a \$9B → \$20B market (SkyQuest / Market.us). Carter's avoids SB 707 fees + EU DPP fines. Three sentences of unit economics. One named pilot ask: "We have drafted a Carter's KIDCYCLE pilot covering 50,000 stretchy basics."
3:30–4:30	Why us + the ask	Team's credentials (chemistry / ML / regulatory split — show the map). The ask: "We're applying to the Cox Cleantech Residency and seeking a Carter's pilot LOI." Map work to Cox thesis: "We're the Nexus Circular of textiles."
4:30–5:00	Closing line	One memorable, repeatable sentence (see below). Stop. Do not over-explain.

Making complex science legible WITHOUT dumbing down

- **One visual analog per concept.** Recyclable elastane = "molecular Velcro with a snap-line." Enzyme = "molecular scissors designed to recognize only that snap-line." Digital Passport = "a nutrition label your phone reads at the recycler."
- **Cite TRL explicitly.** "Today the elastane redesign is at TRL 3 (in-silico structural design). The matched enzyme is at TRL 2 (de novo design, not yet expressed). The Passport is at TRL 6 (working prototype you'll scan in 30 seconds). Our Cox Cleantech Residency milestone is to take elastane + enzyme to TRL 4 with wet-lab validation in 8 weeks." Honesty about TRL is what separates winning deep-tech pitches from over-claimers.
- **Anchor every science point to a dollar.** Judges fade on chemistry; they will not fade on "every 1% elastane reduction in recycle output adds ~\$X/ton to the offtake price."

Handling the "this is aspirational" risk with integrity

The biggest deep-tech hackathon failure mode is overclaiming validation. Counter it preemptively:

- **State the validation roadmap on the same slide as the science**, not separately. Judges respect this; over-claiming gets you destroyed in Q&A.
- **Make ONE thing undeniably real in the demo.** The Digital Recyclability Passport QR scan is your "this is real" anchor. Even if the chemistry is computational, the DPP is functional software judges can scan in 5 seconds.
- **Borrow the Nexus framing:** "Nexus took 10+ years to scale; we're doing the in-silico + DPP layers first to compress that timeline."

Live demo: how to avoid catastrophe

- **Pre-record a 90-second screen-capture backup** open in a second browser window. If WiFi dies, switch tabs and keep going — never apologize. (Medium)
- **Pre-sign all transactions / pre-load all data.** Never debug on stage.
- **Have a physical artifact** (a printed QR card linked to the DPP; a 3D-printed elastane monomer model). Physical objects are disproportionately memorable.
- **Designate ONE presenter** and one demo operator. Do not switch mid-pitch.

Fielding hostile technical Q&A

- **"What's your TRL?"** → State exactly. Never round up.
- **"Has the enzyme been expressed?"** → "Not yet. Our 8-week Residency milestone is heterologous expression in E. coli using a GenScript quote that's in the appendix."

- **"Why won't this be like every other 'magic enzyme' that didn't scale?"** → "Because we co-designed the substrate. Most programs start with a polymer and hope; we designed both sides of the lock-and-key."
- **"Will Carter's pay for this?"** → "Carter's is already paying TerraCycle to downcycle stretch garments into pet bedding. We replace that line item with a fiber-to-fiber loop and an EPR compliance asset. Same line item; different outcome."
- If a judge is wrong, never say "you're wrong." Say "That's a fair concern — here's the data on slide 11."

Closing lines (pick one; memorize cold)

1. "Carter's sells the first clothes a person ever wears. We make sure they're not also the first clothes that outlive them."
2. "Cox built the largest plastics-to-feedstock company in America. We're proposing the textile version — and we'd like to build it here in Atlanta."
3. "By the time the World Cup final whistle blows in July, millions of pounds of children's stretchwear will have hit U.S. landfills. We're here to change what 'play with purpose' means."

Why strong technical projects LOSE hackathons (failure modes to avoid)

Recurring patterns across the cited sources:

1. **No business case** — judges can't sponsor a company they can't picture buying anything. *Carter's-named pilot in your deck = mandatory.*
 2. **Demo failure / debug on stage** — fatal. *Backup video. Always.*
 3. **Feature bloat** — building "17 features" when one would have won (Agrim Singh). *Do the DPP scan + 1 molecular viz. Cut everything else.*
 4. **Buzzword salad without integration** — "AI/blockchain/enzymes" thrown around without showing them working together. *Show one integration explicitly.*
 5. **Unclear problem framing** — pitches that lead with solution, not pain.
 6. **Poor storytelling / reading slides.** *Memorize the first 30 seconds and the last 15 seconds verbatim.*
 7. **Ignoring sponsor tech / thesis** — if you don't name-check Cox Cleantech and Carter's (and Nexus Circular as your archetype), judges from those orgs will not advocate for you.
 8. **Over-rehearsed monotone** — vary energy; pause before key numbers.
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RECOMMENDATIONS (PRIORITIZED, ACTIONABLE)

(a) How to weight and frame the pitch to match the likely rubric

Spend your 5 minutes in this proportion: **30% sustainability impact (with hard numbers)**, **25% live demo of science + DPP**, **20% business case (Carter's pilot, market size, SB 707/ESPR tailwinds)**, **15% innovation/IP**, **10% team + ask**. That mirrors the inferred rubric and the Cox-adjacent rubrics found. If on Day 1 you can't articulate the Carter's pilot economics in two sentences, stop building and fix that first.

(b) Aligning commercialization story with Cox Cleantech's thesis

Treat Cox Cleantech as your real audience and Carter's as your reference customer.

1. **Position as "the Nexus Circular of textiles."** Name-check Nexus in the deck. This is what Cox Cleantech buys.
2. **Make IP visible.** State explicitly: "We're filing a provisional on the elastane monomer + matched enzyme pair within 30 days." Matches Residency eligibility: "Existing patents or active progress toward securing intellectual property licenses." (Cox Enterprises)
3. **Anchor in the Southeast.** Say you'll incorporate in Atlanta; Cox/gener8tor are explicit about this geographic preference.
4. **End with a Residency-shaped ask.** "Our 8-week Residency plan: (1) heterologous enzyme expression, (2) DPP pilot with Carter's KIDCYCLE on one SKU, (3) provisional patent filed. Stipend deployment plan ready."

(c) Quantifying the Carter's case (the slide they'll remember)

Three numbers on one slide:

- **80% of garments contain elastane** (Fashion for Good "Stretching Circularity", Feb 2026) → most kids' stretchwear is currently unrecyclable. (Pangaia)
- **\$10K-\$50K/day** SB 707 penalties starting July 2026 + **eco-modulated EPR fees** that drop for recyclable-by-design SKUs.
- **\$9B → ~\$20B spandex market by 2033** (SkyQuest, Market.us) — the prize for whoever cracks recyclable elastane.

Then one ROI line: "If Carter's converts 10% of stretchwear SKUs to recyclable elastane tagged with our DPP, conservative modeling shows \$X/year in saved EPR + downcycling fees, plus first-mover ESPR positioning in EU."

(d) How to structure and rehearse the 3-5 minute demo

- **Build the pitch on Day 1, not Day 3.** Write the 400-word script first; slides last (per Best3Minutes/MIT). Time it every 12 hours.
- **Rehearse 10+ times**, twice in front of strangers (other teams), once in front of a Cox/gener8tor mentor if available. Iterate the hook until 100% of listeners can repeat the problem in one sentence.
- **The booth pitch is different from the stage pitch.** Memorize a 60-second elevator for Round-1 expo judging plus the 5-minute version for finalists.
- **Two-person operator model:** one presenter (most charismatic), one designated "demo runner" (most reliable). Don't switch mid-pitch.
- **Physical artifacts:** a Carter's onesie, a printed Digital Recyclability Passport QR card judges can scan, a 3D-printed elastane monomer model.
- **Open the kill list:** anything that does not move impact, demo, business case, or memorability gets cut — especially long team intros, the company-logo slide, the table-of-contents slide, and unvalidated claims.

Day-by-day execution (72 hours)

- **Hour 0-6:** Lock the pitch script (one paragraph per pitch beat above). Lock the SKU you'll model (pick one Carter's stretch sleeper). Draft the LOI.
- **Hour 6-36:** In parallel — (i) compute the recyclable-elastane design + render the visualization, (ii) build the DPP web app (Next.js + simple QR), (iii) write the unit-economics spreadsheet for the Carter's pilot.
- **Hour 36-48:** Integrate the three. Record the backup demo video. First full rehearsal.
- **Hour 48-60:** Rehearse to strangers. Cut anything that draws blank stares. Lock slide deck.
- **Hour 60-72:** Final 5 rehearsals. Sleep at least 4 hours the night before. Charge everything twice. Bring two laptops.

CAVEATS

- The hackathon-specific rubric, judges, full prize list, agenda, and explicit confirmation of a Carter's-sponsored "Making & Remaking" track are **not in any indexed primary source** as of June 2, 2026. They likely live behind the gated registration page (lnkd.in/gBW8wvSb). The rubric, weights, and format above are inferred from Cox-adjacent rubrics, gener8tor/Techstars norms, and Cox's stated investment thesis — and should be treated as planning assumptions, not facts. Verify in writing with the organizers immediately after registering.

- The "guaranteed late-round Cleantech Residency interview for track winners" is not corroborated publicly. The Residency program itself is real (announced May 14, 2026) and its application criteria are public. Apply to the Residency in parallel regardless of whether the interview is guaranteed.
- All carbon, water, and waste targets cited for Cox and Carter's are aspirational corporate goals, not verified outcomes. Some Carter's commitments (e.g., 80% landfill diversion by 2025, 100% Higg FEM by 2025) may already be in progress or delayed. Use them as alignment signals, not facts about current performance.
- Carter's FY2024 net sales declined ~3.5% YoY (\$2.844B vs \$2.946B) — meaning Carter's is cost-sensitive and unlikely to fund any pilot that does not have a clear path to cost-down vs. their current TerraCycle line item. Frame your pilot ask accordingly: same-or-lower per-garment cost than current downcycling, with the EPR-fee-reduction and EU-DPP-readiness as the strategic upside.